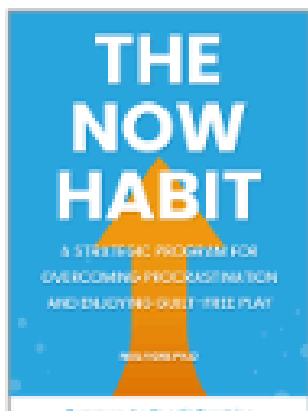




THE NOW HABIT

A Strategic Program for Overcoming
Procrastination and Enjoying Guilt-Free Play

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The Big "So What"

All of us have tasks or goals that we tend to delay or escape from. Contrary to common belief, procrastination is *not* a character flaw or a problem in itself. It is a coping mechanism can be unlearned and reprogrammed. This book presents strategies and tools that can help anyone to overcome procrastination, improve your quality of work, *and* free up guilt-free time to play and relax.



Introduction



Most habitual procrastinators are aware of their tendencies, but are unable to break free from them. Common advice to "work harder", "just do it" or "get organized" simply don't work because they fail to address the root of the issue:

- Procrastination is a coping mechanism that we use to deal with the stress and anxiety associated with certain tasks and our self-image. The only way to eliminate it is to tackle the underlying fears and self-condemnation.
- The truth is, no one is an absolute procrastinator. There are always activities that we willingly dive into with enthusiasm. The Now Habit is built on positive psychology and the Maslow hierarchy of needs. It's based on the belief that humans have a natural desire to do well. By harnessing that innate drive and overcoming our fears or insecurities, we can start to take action *now*.
- With time, you'll not only enjoy greater productivity, but also free yourself from the guilt and shame of procrastination, feel more motivated, improve your self-

KEY QUOTES

"The skills and strategies of the Now Habit program will let you think of yourself as a producer, feel like a producer, and act like a producer."

"Procrastination is a mechanism for coping with the anxiety associated with starting or completing any task or decision."

*"The healthy individual has an appetite for fruitful activity and for a high quality of life."
—George Bernard Shaw*

esteem, and have more time for guilt-free enjoyment while improving the quality of your work. You will think, feel, and act like a producer, not a procrastinator.



This summary is organized into 2 parts: we'll start by explaining the whys and hows of procrastination, before zooming in on various powerful tools that you can use to overcome procrastination and unlock your productivity.



Why and How We Procrastinate



Why we Procrastinate



Procrastination is not a character defect or a sign that we're lazy. Many of us have been taught from young not to let praise get to our heads, and never to rest on our laurels. We feel guilty when we're playing or relaxing when we "should" be working harder and improving ourselves. We procrastinate to cope with underlying issues like perfectionism, low self-esteem, fear of failure/success, and negative feelings about ourselves or our work.



Habits are learned when an activity is instantly followed by a reward. Procrastination is rewarding because it provides temporary relief from our stress and anxiety. We feel even more justified if the task eventually takes care of itself or is handled by someone/something else. In particular, we use procrastination to achieve 3 things:

- Express resentment or resistance toward authorities and our sense of powerlessness. We use procrastination to indirectly rebel against or sabotage our "oppressors".
- Avoid the fear of failure or disappointment, which often comes from perfectionism and self-criticism.
- Avoid our fear of success. We hold back our best effort due to:
 - (i) The *conflict* between our desire for advancement and our loved ones' demands for our time/attention.

KEY QUOTES

"Generally we are taught that procrastination is the problem, rather than a symptom of other problems."

"Our real distress comes from the constant anxiety of delaying, from guilt about the inferior quality of projects completed at the last minute, and from deep regrets about life's missed opportunities."

"People don't procrastinate just to be ornery or because they're irrational. They procrastinate because it makes sense, given how vulnerable they feel to criticism, failure, and their own perfectionism."

- (ii) The *disincentives* associated with the end of a project, e.g. looking for a new job after graduation.
- (iii) Our *fear of eventual failure*. Each time we succeed, we're presented with an even-higher bar. The higher we go, the higher the standards and competition become. So, it seems like a matter of time before we'll fail.



People who procrastinate habitually get stuck in a vicious cycle. They procrastinate because of certain fears or anxiety. The more they procrastinate, the more anxious they feel, and the more they criticize themselves and lose confidence. This leads to an even stronger urge to procrastinate. The cycle continues until they label themselves as a procrastinator, and can't even enjoy their leisure time without guilt.



How we Procrastinate



Each of us procrastinates differently. Over the next week, observe your own tendencies and identify your procrastination patterns so you can break them.



Know how you spend your time. Divide your day into 3-4 segments (e.g. morning, afternoon, evening), and record the time spent for every activity. You can also label your work activities with "A" (most important), "B" (important) or "C" (least important). After a few days, you'll have a good idea of how you typically spend your time, including how much time is spent on email/phone, working, eating, socializing etc. Chances are, the bulk of your time is not used for important or high-priority work.



Create a procrastination log. Allow yourself to procrastinate as usual, then take note of when/how you procrastinate without judging yourself. Whenever you put something off, write down these details:

- When and what: Record the date and time, the activity involved and its priority level. You may start to notice that you tend to procrastinate more during certain days/time, or for certain type of tasks (e.g. detailed tasks like tax filing, or "big" projects like an annual plan).

KEY QUOTES

"[Others] can never make you into a victim or a procrastinator. Only you can do that."

"Identifying how you go about doing anything is essential to improving your performance."

"The first major step out of procrastination is to become aware of how fear leads to your old patterns and how creating safety leads to productivity."

- Why and how: Write down your thoughts and feelings, the justifications you give yourself, how you try to avoid the task, and how you feel after that. These help you to identify the attitudes, beliefs, self-talk and responses associated with certain tasks.

Sample Procrastination Log					
Date & Time	Activity & Priority	Thoughts & Feelings	Justification	Attempted solution	Resultant Thoughts & Feelings
15/12 10am	Prepare annual plan, A	There's so much to cover	Must think about it	Surfed the internet	Guilty and stressed
16/12 3.20pm	Fix the shelf, B	I should but I don't want to	Nice weather	Go for a walk	Relaxed from the walk



Reprogram your Habits: From Procrastinator to Producer



The Now Habit strategy comes with several powerful tools you can use to overcome procrastination and reprogram yourself to be a producer.



Create a Psychological Safety Net



If you were asked to walk across a wooden plank on the floor, you'd probably do it without hesitation. But if you had to walk across the same plank 200m above ground, you'll hesitate for fear of falling. Now, if there's a fire raging behind you, you'll somehow find a way to cross the plank to safety. This analogy mirrors what happens when we procrastinate: we imagine a task to be much scarier than it is, then we put it off until the situation becomes so dire that we have no choice but to do it. This creates undue stress and worsens the negative feelings associated with the work and our self-image.



The solution is to create a safety net, so crossing the plank no longer seems so dangerous. A psychological safety net can reduce the perceived threat of failure or imperfection, and help you to bounce back stronger from your mistakes.

KEY QUOTES

"The absurd lengths taken to procrastinate indicate how much pain you've trained yourself to associate with the task."

"Procrastination has been learned, and it can be unlearned. You need to develop alternative tools for coping with your fears."

- Consider alternative options instead of being fixated on 1 option. Develop backup plans, so that any failure won't seem like the end of the world.
- Use positive self-talk to remind yourself: "Whatever happens, I will survive, bounce back and find a way to carry on." Think of all the successful people who've bounced back from major setbacks in life. Create a space where you're safe from judgement and criticism, especially from yourself.



Use Positive Self-Talk



Our self-talk shapes our attitudes to determine how we think, feel, and act.

- We react negatively to words like "I have to" or "I should" because they're associated with pressure and unpleasant tasks.
 - (i) "Have to's" bring up feelings of stress—we feel victimized and compelled to do something we don't want to do. It creates an internal conflict, since your logical mind says you must do it, but your subconscious mind rejects it. The more you struggle, the more unpleasant the task seems.
 - (ii) "Should's" bring up feelings of envy or depression as we focus on the gap between reality and ideal, or feel guilty/disappointed for not doing/achieving what we "should".
- On the other hand, words like "I choose," "I decide," or "I will" remind us that we have a choice in what, when, where or how we do something. They focus our energy positively toward a desired outcome, so we shift from resistance to commitment. That's why people who become pregnant may suddenly improve their diet or quit smoking, even though they had failed to do so in the past.



Reprogram your attitude by replacing negative self-talk with positive ones.

KEY QUOTES

"Through a language of choice and commitment you'll learn to direct your energy toward a goal, feeling empowered rather than victimized."

- Learn to say "no" without guilt/shame, e.g. "No, I have other priorities", "No, I need more time to consider", "No, I don't accept these terms".
- Replace negative messages with positive ones:
 - (i) Replace "I have to" with "I choose to."
 - (ii) Replace "I must finish" with "When/where can I start?"
 - (iii) Replace "This is too big" with "I can take one small step".
 - (iv) Replace "I must be perfect" with "I can be perfectly human".
 - (v) Replace "I have no time to play/relax" with "I must take time to play/relax".
- Switch from the mindset of a procrastinator to that of a producer: "I choose to start on one small imperfect step knowing I have plenty of time for play."



Use Old Habits to Trigger New Ones



Whenever you decide not to procrastinate, you're changing your neural pathways to weaken your old habits and create/strengthen new ones. In this way, you can unlearn your habits in the same way you learned them.



Push vs pull. The push method assumes that humans are lazy and can only be motivated through threats or punishments. The pull method assumes that humans are naturally curious and will persevere with the right incentive.

- We're more likely to start working on a task if it generates short-term rewards. We're less motivated by a vague promise of long-term rewards, and are demotivated by immediate pain/isolation. Focus on the rewards at the end of every small milestone, e.g. you can take the whole weekend off to play if you finish your project by Friday, or can relax for the year once you hit your sales target this quarter.

KEY QUOTES



Use Guilt-Free Play to Inspire Quality Work



Prioritize guilt-free play-time by scheduling it in your calendar. This simple step will inspire higher quality work because:

- It removes your fear that work will deprive you of time for enjoyment.
- With less time left for work, you'll feel motivated to make every minute count. You'll approach your work with more focus and seek to finish your tasks in less time.
- The extra exercise, relaxation and stimulation give you more energy and inspiration, to bring back excitement and creativity into your work, learning and problem-solving.



As a result, you break the vicious cycle of procrastination and start a positive cycle of creativity and productivity.



Overcome Blocks to Action with 3 Tools

The next 3 tools help to overcome the 3 key blocks that trigger procrastination: the fear of being overwhelmed, the fear of failure, and the fear of not finishing. These blocks reinforce one another, and demolishing 1 block also weakens the others.



To tackle the fear of being overwhelmed, use Three-dimensional thinking and the Reverse Calendar:

- If you're feeling overwhelmed by the immensity of a project, remember 3 things to ease your anxiety: (i) you don't have to start at the "right" place, (ii) you can learn as you go (instead of having to know everything now), and (iii) it's ok not to finish immediately.
- Use the Reverse Calendar to divide a big project into small, manageable parts with sub-deadlines over the coming days/weeks. Break this down further into bite-sized steps within your control. You now have checkpoints to allay your fear of going in the wrong direction, and know how much time you have to finish each step.

KEY QUOTES

"Enjoying guilt-free play is part of a cycle that will lead you to higher levels of quality, creative work."



To tackle the fears of failure and imperfection, finish the work of worrying. Don't waste energy fretting about a potential problem—use the energy to develop solutions and plans to address the threat. Consider: (i) What's the worst that could happen and how likely/unlikely it is, (ii) what you can do in that scenario, (iii) how you can lessen your pain and increase your happiness even then, (iv) what alternatives you have or create, and (v) what you can do now to reduce the chances of the worst-case event and increase your chances of success.



To tackle the fear of not finishing, use persistent starting. Shift your focus away from the finish-line and keep asking “when can I start on the next step?” If you keep taking 1 step at a time, you *will* finish the task. Remember: preparing to start is not the same as starting, and can actually be a form of procrastination. Don't waste energy berating yourself on your slow progress or how you should've started earlier. If you find yourself making excuses not to finish (e.g. “I need more time to perfect it”), remind yourself that your work is what can be accomplished *within* the deadlines.



Use The Unschedule



Procrastination doesn't remove the need to get the work done. You're better off just doing it. The Unschedule helps you get started, 30 minutes at time. It's basically (i) a weekly calendar of your nonwork activities and (ii) a record of actual work done.

- The Unschedule combines several behavioral and psychological principles to help you achieve realistic timekeeping, overcome your fears, associate your work with success/rewards, do more quality work and enjoy guilt-free play time. It builds your confidence by (i) motivating you with short periods of work followed by immediate rewards, and (ii) showing a visible record of how much focused, uninterrupted work you've done daily.



Use these guidelines to start implementing your Unschedule:

- Start by filling your planner with nonwork activities (e.g. meals, exercise, sleeping, meetings, recreation,

KEY QUOTES

“Procrastination is an ineffective way to cope with worrying because it stalls action and simply piles up more worries.”

“Keep on starting, and finishing will take care of itself.”

“The choice is not working or not working, but which type of work; even feeling guilty because of procrastinating takes some effort.”

socialization). You'll realize that you have only a few hours a day for real work.

- Fill in the work hours only after you've finished 30 min of uninterrupted work. Don't record the time if you stop before 30 min, or step away for a snack/call.
- After each work period, reward yourself with a break or switch to a more enjoyable task. Before going for a recreational or social activity, take 30 minutes to work on a high-priority project.
- Add up the number of quality hours worked each day/week and give yourself a pat on the back. You may soon feel excited to see how many work hours you can clock each day.
- Devote at least 1 day a week just for rest and recreation (and perhaps some small chores). After a rest, you'll feel more motivated to return to your high-priority projects.
- Focus on "when is the next time I can start?" and keep taking 1 small step at a time. Don't try to finish an entire project, or work non-stop for 3 hours. Just aim for just 30 minutes of quality, focused work.
- Never end on a low note. If you're stuck, use another 5-10 minutes to at least come up with a partial solution.



Within 2 weeks, you'd have established a rhythm and have a better sense of your schedule. You can now start to make adjustments:

- Consider starting earlier, reprioritizing your tasks, or dropping/delegating some projects to free up time for your primary goal. Ideally, use your first 30min-slot for your highest-priority task, followed by the next-highest priority task and so on.
- If you can't get started even with 30 min of focused work, then take a full day's rest to do something you really want to do. You'll probably feel more eager to return to work the next day.
- Make a firm commitment to your scheduled leisure activities (e.g. sleep, meals, exercise, socialization).

KEY QUOTES

Sample Procrastination Log							
Hours	Sun	Mon	Tue	Wed	Thu	Fri	Sat
6-7am							
7-8am							
8-9am							
9-10am							
10-11am							
11-12pm							
12-1pm							
1-2pm							
2-3pm							
3-4pm							
4-5pm							
5-6pm							
6-7pm							
7-8pm							
8-9pm							
9-10pm							
10-11pm							
11-12am							
12-1am							
1-2am							
2-3am							
3-4am							
4-5am							
5-6am							



Work in the Flow State



Peak performance comes when we're in a state of flow, i.e. we feel calm, focused, and so absorbed in our work that even the most challenging task feels effortless. Yet, you can't feel creative or inspired if you're constantly judging or criticizing every step you take. To use your brain optimally, you must suspend your criticism/judgement and allow your creativity and inspiration to flow. You can organize the ideas later to meet specific requirements or standards.



Train yourself to get into the flow state:

KEY QUOTES

"Working in the flow state or in the zone removes the emotional need to procrastinate and accelerates your progress toward your goals."

- Don't impose linear structures prematurely during the initial steps/drafts as your idea is still unfolding.
- Before each 30-minute work session, use 2 minutes for a focusing exercise to shift into a relaxed, creative state of mind. Sit upright and breathe deeply. Hold your breath for a moment, and then imagine your tension flowing out as you exhale slowly. With each exhale, release any remaining tension and allow the deep relaxation to flow down your entire body. Let go of all thoughts/worries about the past, as well as your anticipations for the future. Bring your energy and focus to the present and what you choose to do right now.
- In the book, Dr. Fiore also suggests additional self-talk and a 12-15 min relaxation exercise to prepare for your focusing exercise.



Use Controlled Setbacks to Train your Responses



Use planned setbacks to practice how to counter your negative habits and switch to a productive one. The more you practice, the more you build your brain's neural pathways to facilitate peak performance.

- Choose projects/tasks that you're likely to procrastinate on, and deliberately switch to a producer mindset using the various techniques above (e.g. switch from "I have to" to "I choose to", apply the focusing exercise or the Unschedule). Observe the shift in your own thoughts and feelings.
- Through the practices, you can build hardiness and resilience to bounce back from setbacks and persevere through difficulties.
- Practice how to master your distractions during focused work.
 - (i) You may suddenly feel anxious about a deadline or concern, think of an outstanding task, fantasize over something, or have an idea/inspiration. Just jot these down in a notebook so you can deal with them later, e.g. put the fantasy in your guilt-free playbook as a potential reward in the future.

KEY QUOTES

"Great works are performed,
not by strength, but
perseverance."
—Samuel Johnson

- (ii) Most distractions can be addressed after your half-hour of focused work, with the exception of strong emotions (especially if you're using work to escape your feelings about a loved one or a major concern). Pause briefly to acknowledge your emotions and develop a plan to address them later. This will give you the peace of mind to return to your work.



You can also use mental rehearsals to prepare for your focused work sessions. Use mental imagery to call up positive feelings and enter a focused, relaxed state of mind. For example, if a project seems like huge, thick wall, then imagine a small door that you can simply walk through. You can also visualize sitting at your desk and immersing yourself in your work with focus and enjoyment.



Set Effective Goals



Learn to set effective goals, so you can achieve them and build your confidence.

- It's better to set a few key goals that you're committed to, than to waste energy procrastinating on many trivial goals.
- Set realistic, observable, concrete goals with an action verb (e.g. "I will make 10 sales calls by Friday 5pm", not "I'll finish my calls next week"). Include an action-oriented sub-goal that tells you exactly what you must do today.
- If you're repeatedly drawn to a goal that you can't find time for, then treat it as a wish rather than a goal. That will free you to focus fully on the present goal.



Managing the Procrastinators in your Life



Managing procrastinators at work. Now that you understand procrastination, you'll see why many management practices actually backfire. Managers who use threats and pressure only increase people's fears, anxiety and tendency to

KEY QUOTES

"Nothing is so fatiguing as the eternal hanging on of an uncompleted task."
—William James

procrastinate. On the other hand, successful managers use words and images that evoke choice and inspiration. They state priorities clearly and give frequent rewards and praises.

- Commitment, not compliance. Successful leaders don't demand compliance, e.g. "You have to finish this by today" or "You better make sure there're no mistakes." They invite commitment by giving people a sense of choice and trust, e.g. "Can you get a draft to me by end of today?" or "Can I count on you to manage this important account?"
- Action steps vs end-point. Effective managers don't just focus on the finish-line, e.g. "Get this done by Friday." They clearly communicate how to get started, and break down a project into a series of sub-goals, e.g. "When can you start on a first draft?" or "We need to table the proposal next Tuesday, so can you send me a first draft in 2 days' time?"
- Criticism vs praise/rewards. Good managers don't attack people's character, e.g. "Why can't you ever get things right?" Instead, they offer praises and constructive, action-oriented feedback, e.g. "That was a really clear and succinct report", or "You did a great job handling that angry customer." They also offer rewards and encouragement whenever a sub-goal is achieved.
- They state their priorities clearly, and stick to their decisions. When they're unsure of the correct priorities, they involve their team members in the decision-making process.



The same principles apply to procrastinators at home.

- Don't treat your family members like kids or blame them for not living up to your expectations. Instead, appeal to them as responsible, autonomous individuals, e.g. "I know I'm obsessed about being on time, so I have to leave in exactly 30 minutes. It's great if you can join me, but that's up to you." Then, be prepared to leave in 30 minutes even if the other person isn't ready.
- The best way to influence behavior is by role modeling what it means to be a producer who works and plays to the fullest.

KEY QUOTES

"Frequent encouragement helps a worker to feel motivated now while on the path to distant rewards."